BOOKS

THE ETERNAL MOTHER

Prayaag Akbar's new novel delves into the complexities of contemporary India

After the sumptuous durbar of oddities that Prayaag Akbar created for his dystopian view of Delhi in his award-winning first novel *Leila* (2017), whose dark towers and turrets earned instant recognition on Netflix where it awaits a second season, he can be forgiven for rooting in the attic of pre-Independence glory and resurrecting an old lady from its ateliers—*Mother India*!

Perish the thought! Mother India, as we are reminded, is always young. Here she's morphed into a tender young woman named Nisha from the hills around Nainital with limpid green eyes and a diamond-shaped birthmark on her cheek. She is trekking to a temple on a hill and pausing to take a selfie against the gently frothing mist of the Corbett Falls. Need we add that her matching cascade of curls falling across her shoulder gives her, as we are informed, "an other-worldly quality"? It is this moment that sets the action rolling and creates a resonance in the distant heartbeats of our hero Mayank, a lowly content creator beavering away in Delhi at the behest of his waxed handlebar moustachioed boss, who is a dab hand at disseminating right-wing *gyaan* to believers.

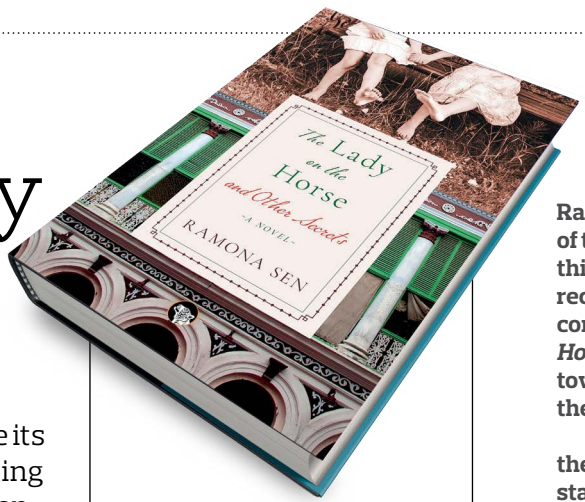
Mother India melds into the handsets of Generation Z and assumes a whole new dimension: a pixelated salesgirl. Fleeing the hills, Nisha finds herself as a trainee salesgirl in an upmarket Delhi emporium selling Japanese chocolate under the supervision of a lubricious sales manager called Siddharth. There's a wonderfully observed vignette of a

MOTHER INDIA MELDS INTO THE HANDSETS OF GENERATION Z AND ASSUMES A WHOLE NEW DIMENSION: A PIXELATED SALESGIRL

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Family Saga

RAMONA SEN's *The Lady on the Horse* doesn't lose its pace while narrating the story of five generations of a family in Calcutta



THE LADY ON THE HORSE AND OTHER SECRETS
by Ramona Sen
SPEAKING TIGER
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Ramona Sen is best known as the author of the 2016 novel *Crème Brûlée*, something of a sleeper hit and among the best-received works of commercial fiction to come out of India. With *The Lady on the Horse and Other Secrets*, Sen has turned towards literary fiction and, luckily for us, the secret sauce hasn't deserted her.

The novel follows five generations of the Lahiri family in a non-linear fashion, starting with Dipendra Nath and Pritilata, *khansama* and seamstress, respectively, serving the British at the beginning of the 20th century. The couple's rise to wealth and fortune is accompanied by a bagful of secrets and the not-infrequent hypocrisy of behaving like 'brown sahibs', even as the future holds increasingly turbulent times. There are memorable characters